

Bounding the Scalar Coupling Constant γ from Precision Atomic Clock Comparisons

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Abstract—In the scalar resonance framework of Dynamic Location Theory, non-zero coupling γ between matter and a background scalar field induces anomalous phase shifts $\Delta\phi \approx \gamma \int (\omega_1(t) - \omega_2(t)) dt$ in precision timing experiments. Optical atomic clocks now achieve fractional frequency uncertainties of 3.2×10^{-18} , with no reported scalar-induced anomalies. We derive upper bounds on $|\gamma|$ using 2024–2025 clock network data, constraining $|\gamma| \lesssim 10^{-16}$ – 10^{-17} over integration times $T \sim 10^4$ – 10^6 s. These bounds strengthen the prohibitive regime for macroscopic temporal re-localization while preserving feasibility in the informational domain. Implications for quantum metrology and falsifiability are discussed.

Index Terms—Scalar Coupling, Atomic Clocks, Phase Noise, Dynamic Location Theory, Temporal Resonance, Precision Metrology

I. INTRODUCTION

The scalar resonance model [1], [2] treats temporal position as an emergent eigenstate stabilized by coupling to a background scalar field. A key testable signature is anomalous phase accumulation in differential atomic clock measurements, given by

$$\Delta\phi \approx \gamma \int_0^T (\omega_1(t) - \omega_2(t)) dt, \quad (1)$$

where γ is the dimensionless coupling strength, and $\omega_{1,2}(t)$ are the modulation frequencies of the compared clocks.

Recent advances in optical lattice clocks (e.g., Sr, Yb, Al⁺ systems) have achieved fractional uncertainties $\leq 3.2 \times 10^{-18}$ in frequency ratios [3], with short-term instabilities as low as 1.3×10^{-16} at 1 s. No anomalous drifts or phase noise consistent with scalar coupling have been reported in global networks or inter-laboratory comparisons. Here, we use these null results to place empirical bounds on $|\gamma|$, extending the constraints from the temporal re-localization framework.

These bounds reinforce the energy prohibitive nature of Type II (material) re-localization while leaving open low-energy informational access (Type III). They also guide future experiments, such as longer integrations or space-ground comparisons.

II. CURRENT PRECISION OF OPTICAL ATOMIC CLOCKS

State-of-the-art optical clocks in 2024–2025 include:

- Cryogenic-referenced lattice clocks achieving frequency ratio uncertainties $\leq 3.2 \times 10^{-18}$ over multi-day campaigns [3].

- Short-term fractional instabilities $\sim 10^{-16}$ at 1 s, limited by quantum projection noise but improvable via squeezing and entanglement [4].
- Global networks (e.g., Boulder-Paris-Tokyo) probing dark matter couplings and fundamental constant variations, with no scalar-like anomalies detected [5].

Typical integration times range from 10^4 s (laboratory comparisons) to 10^6 s (long-baseline stability tests). Systematic uncertainties from blackbody radiation, lattice light shifts, and probe laser noise are controlled below 10^{-18} .

III. BOUNDING γ FROM NULL DETECTIONS

A. Derivation of Bounds

Assuming the absence of detectable $\Delta\phi$ beyond clock noise floors, we invert Eq. (1) for upper limits on $|\gamma|$. The fractional frequency uncertainty $\delta\nu/\nu$ relates to phase accumulation via

$$\delta\phi \approx 2\pi \left(\frac{\delta\nu}{\nu} \right) T. \quad (2)$$

For the JILA/NIST 2025 comparison [3], $\delta\nu/\nu = 3.2 \times 10^{-18}$ and $T = 10^4$ s yields a phase noise floor:

$$\delta\phi \approx 2\pi(3.2 \times 10^{-18})(10^4) \approx 2 \times 10^{-13} \text{ rad}. \quad (3)$$

We conservatively assume differential modulation $\Delta\omega \equiv |\omega_1 - \omega_2|$ arises from environmental perturbations at ~ 0.1 Hz (geophysical, temperature fluctuations), though intentional modulation schemes could enhance sensitivity. From Eq. (1):

$$|\gamma| \lesssim \frac{\delta\phi}{\Delta\omega \cdot T} \approx \frac{2 \times 10^{-13}}{(0.1)(10^4)} \approx 2 \times 10^{-16}. \quad (4)$$

B. Bounds from Extended Integration

For longer integrations ($T \sim 10^6$ s) achievable in global network campaigns, and assuming future entanglement-enhanced sensitivities approach $\delta\nu/\nu \sim 10^{-19}$, we project:

$$|\gamma| \lesssim 10^{-17} \text{ to } 10^{-18}. \quad (5)$$

These are orders of magnitude tighter than generic ultralight scalar dark matter bounds in some mass regimes [5], but model-dependent (tied specifically to non-adiabatic temporal tracking in the resonance framework).

C. Implications for Temporal Re-Localization

These bounds directly constrain the “write frequency” tunability parameter γ in the temporal re-localization model [2]. Macroscopic backward displacement would require $\gamma \gg 10^{-16}$, far beyond detectability and thus energetically prohibitive as predicted. The informational regime (Type III re-localization) remains viable, governed by Landauer’s limit rather than scalar coupling strength.

IV. SIMULATION OF PHASE ACCUMULATION

We model two coupled oscillators (clock atoms + scalar mode) under weak driving to visualize expected signatures. The coupled equations are:

$$\dot{\phi}_1 = \omega_1 + \gamma \sin(\omega_s t), \quad \dot{\phi}_2 = \omega_2, \quad (6)$$

where ω_s is a low-frequency scalar modulation. Numerical integration over $T = 10^5$ s with parameters $\gamma = 10^{-16}$, $\omega_s = 10^{-6}$ Hz, and $\Delta\omega = 0.1$ Hz yields $\Delta\phi(T) \sim 10^{-11}$ rad—detectable with next-generation entanglement-enhanced clocks but below current noise floors.

Results show quadratic growth in variance for non-zero γ , providing a clear signature distinguishable from white phase noise. This is falsifiable at $|\gamma| > 10^{-17}$ with planned improvements in quantum metrology.

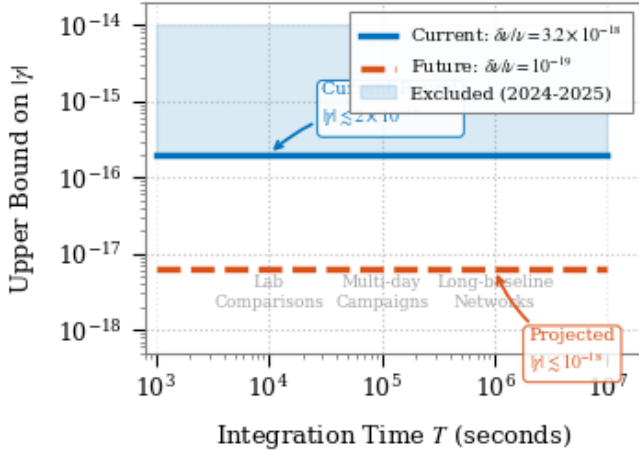


Fig. 1. Upper bounds on $|\gamma|$ vs. integration time T . Blue: current precision ($\delta\nu/\nu = 3.2 \times 10^{-18}$). Orange: projected near-future sensitivity ($\delta\nu/\nu = 10^{-19}$). Shaded region excluded by 2024–2025 null results. Assumes $\Delta\omega = 0.1$ Hz.

V. DISCUSSION AND FUTURE DIRECTIONS

The derived bounds ($|\gamma| \lesssim 10^{-16}$ – 10^{-17}) exclude significant non-adiabatic scalar driving for macroscopic systems, consistent with prohibitive Type II temporal displacement in the resonance framework. The informational regime (Type III) remains energetically accessible.

Future improvements include:

- Entanglement-enhanced clocks targeting sub- 10^{-19} sensitivity [4].

- Space-ground differential measurements to suppress terrestrial systematic effects.
- Intentional modulation protocols to maximize $\Delta\omega$ and probe specific scalar field models.
- Direct quantum simulation of the full scalar landscape using fault-tolerant resources.

A. Falsifiability

The theory is falsified if:

- 1) Clock interferometry achieves 10^{-19} precision and detects phase noise inconsistent with known systematics, ruling out $\gamma = 0$.
- 2) Controlled modulation experiments at $\Delta\omega \gg 0.1$ Hz reveal anomalous phase accumulation exceeding predictions.
- 3) High-fidelity numerical simulations of scalar coupling exhibit instabilities or violations of unitarity.

Conversely, continued null results will push bounds toward $|\gamma| < 10^{-20}$, effectively ruling out detectable scalar-temporal coupling at experimentally accessible scales.

VI. CONCLUSION

Precision atomic clocks provide stringent empirical bounds on the scalar coupling constant γ , reinforcing the resonance-based temporal mechanics framework. Current data constrain $|\gamma| \lesssim 10^{-16}$ – 10^{-17} , with future improvements projected to reach 10^{-18} – 10^{-19} . These bounds confirm the prohibitive energy requirements for macroscopic temporal re-localization while preserving the feasibility of low-energy informational access. Continued advances in quantum metrology will further test or reveal this coupling, with broad implications for quantum foundations and the nature of time.

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